

IBM Pulls The Plug

IBM has finally decided to pull the curtains on OS/2. The company has said that all sales of OS/2 will end this December, and support for the pre-emptive multi-tasking OS will end in December 2006. IBM has posted a migration page to help OS/2 users switch easily to Linux.



Tuning Into iTunes

iTunes, the music download service by Apple, has seen more than 500 million downloads since the time it was launched. At 99 cents (Rs 43) a download, that's a whole lot of money Apple has pocketed. No wonder the iPod has been Apple's single largest revenue driver.



Enter

Atul Kasbekar
Photographer

He's India's number one photographer, and one of the first to have professionally shifted to digital photography. Here's what Kasbekar has to say about technology.

What does technology mean to you?

I see change as the only constant in technology. The equipment I use in my work is a means to an end. For instance, with the onset of digital photography, I, too, adapted to it.

How did the transition to digital help?

Digital cameras save one step in the shooting and film developing process as you can click directly with the camera, see the image for yourself and the picture is ready to go.

What gadgets do you own?

I am not a gadget freak per se. Consider my mobile phone—I have been using it for the last year-and-a-half, and haven't considered buying another, since the one I'm using is still serviceable. However, I do own three iPods—all of which I got as presents!

How do you go about buying a particular gadget?

I have a team of assistants who are very tech savvy. If I need to choose between, say, two new cameras, we collect all the info about the products, discuss their pros and cons and then make the purchase. My time is precious—there is a lot more I would like to do in life. So I don't mind delegating work that needs a good understanding of the nuances of technology.

KEEP TALKING

Calls On The Fly

How often have you rued the fact that your cell phone does not have a 'flight' mode that would allow you to stay connected throughout your flight? Well, if Siemens and Airbus have their way, such thoughts could well be a thing of the past.

For their part, Airbus will build the technology into its existing electronics systems, market it to airlines and maintain it.

OnAir, a joint venture of Airbus and air-transport IT and telecoms specialist SITA, has said that complete systems would be

to switch the on-board mobile-phone system into different modes, such as text-only, to ensure quiet times in the cabin.

LOOKING OVER YOUR SHOULDER

Listening In On Your In-flight Internet

If being able to make iPhone calls is the first step, the next obvious step would be to provide Internet connections to passengers on airplanes. Before that can happen, though, American federal law enforcement officials are asking regulators for the authority to be able to tap into any passenger's Internet use within 10 minutes of obtaining court authorisation.

With a large number of companies entering the fray to provide in-flight communication services for passengers, security agencies across the world are gearing up to deal with potential threats. Boeing's Connexion system allows passengers to plug in to a wired Ethernet port or connect wirelessly using 802.11b. The service is available on select flights on a handful of international carriers, such as Lufthansa, Singapore Airlines and Korean Air.



The two giants have come together to form a joint venture to develop technology that could make ordinary mobile phone calls possible for all passengers. Siemens will supply lightweight on-board base stations for GSM networks and channel selectors that will ensure mobile calls do not interfere with aircraft systems or networks on the ground.

ready for installation on the Airbus A320 family of aircraft flying on Western European routes by the second half of 2006. The technology is also suitable for aircraft made by Airbus' rival, Boeing. Boeing's Connexion unit, which already offers on-board broadband access, also expects to start selling cell phone services to passengers by next year.

OnAir also added that aircraft crew would be able